



# *Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship*

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9 September 2020

Robert Haché, PhD  
President and Vice-Chancellor  
Laurentian University  
935 Ramsey Lake Rd.  
Sudbury, ON P3E 2C6

Dear Dr Haché:

I am writing as president of the Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship (SAFS), an organization of university faculty members and others dedicated to the defense of academic freedom and the merit principle in higher education. (For further information, please see our website at [www.safs.ca](http://www.safs.ca).)

You wrote in your statement of 22 June, “Dr. David Lesbarrères will be stepping down from his day-to-day functions as Dean of the Faculty of Graduate Studies for an indeterminate period, effective immediately.” SAFS urges that Dr Lesbarrères be reinstated immediately.

Dr Lesbarrères was encouraged to step down because he had, in the words of your statement of 9 June, “issued an inappropriate and offensive tweet,” a tweet that “hurt many people in our Laurentian community and beyond.”

Dr Lesbarrères’s tweet was not inappropriate in any way. It simply expressed shock at racist comments being directed against white students and asked that we remember our common descent or common humanity.

Those who think Dr Lesbarrères said something false or who object to the tone or to the phrase “all lives matter” are free to criticize the tweet as they wish. Universities rightfully pride themselves as places hospitable to discussion and disputation.

Of course, feelings might be hurt when one hears something with which one disagrees, but that is part of the university experience. No one is harmed or wronged by hearing a view that one would not like to hear. Students (and faculty members) acquire the skills and attitudes of thinkers and academics precisely by confronting views that disturb them.

That Dr Lesbarrères stepped down as dean following your statement of 9 June will certainly create a chilly climate on campus for expression and discussion. Students and faculty members will keep their views, concerns, and ideas to themselves for fear of bringing opprobrium or sanction down on their heads.

The treatment Dr Lesbarrères has received will also force faculty members thinking to apply for administrative positions to reconsider. That cannot but have deleterious effects throughout Laurentian.

After your paragraph regarding the tweet, you use your statement of 9 June “to reiterate that I condemn any racism on campus.” Your condemning racism in this statement falsely suggests that Dr Lesbarrères’s tweet can be construed as racist.

To sum up: Dr Lesbarrères did nothing at all wrong by issuing his tweet. Your statements declaring the tweet inappropriate, offensive, and hurtful, and then Laurentian’s decision to accept that Dr Lesbarrères step down, will dampen enthusiasm on campus for discussion of and research into timely matters. Laurentian’s unfortunate response to Dr Lesbarrères’s tweet will make it difficult for Laurentian to recruit high quality administrators.

SAFS encourages Laurentian to reinstate Dr Lesbarrères immediately as Dean of the Faculty of Graduate Studies and to apologize to the Laurentian University community for having betrayed academic values. You might also wish to make a statement to the Laurentian community affirming freedom of expression on campus and making clear that neither being offended nor hurt by someone’s views warrants anything other than robust discussion.

We respectfully ask you to respond to our letter. With your permission, we will post your response along with this letter on our website.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Mark Mercer', with a stylized, flowing script.

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